

one

Prehistory

Jazz emerged as a recognizable music around 1900. At least that date seems as good as any; a few years one way or the other hardly matter. Before that lies its pre-history, with which this chapter deals: the period when the various social and musical components of the future jazz emerged and fused. After that comes the double story of the evolution of jazz and of its unique and triumphant expansion.

THE COMPONENTS

There is not much disagreement among the experts about the African components of jazz. Most of the slaves imported into the Southern states of the U.S.A. were West Africans, the French (in whose Louisiana territory jazz first emerged) having a special preference for slaves from Dahomey. Little of the social organization of the West African blacks survived in the slave society, except certain religious cults, notably the Haitian and Louisianan *vodun* ('Voodoo') with its ritual music, and this, as Marshall Stearns points out, survived better under Catholic than under Protestant slave owners, for the Catholics did not greatly worry about their slaves' souls and tolerated a barely Christianized paganism among them. Hence Africanism survived in a purer form in the French zone of the U.S.A. In the Protestant zones, African cults went underground, or were transmuted into shouting revival music with far greater European admixtures. Among the musical Africanisms which the slaves brought with them were rhythmic complexity, certain non-classical musical scales—some of them, like the ordinary pentatonic, familiar in non-classical European music^{*}—and certain musical patterns. The most characteristic of these are the 'call-and-response' patterns which dominate the blues,

and indeed most of jazz, and are preserved in their most archaic form (as one might expect) in the music of primitive black gospel congregations, with its echo of 'shouting dances'. Certain types of functional songs were no doubt also brought over by the slaves: 'field-hollers' and work-songs in general, satirical songs and the like. Such characteristic African musical practices as vocal and rhythmical polyphony, and the ubiquitous improvisation also belong to the slaves' musical heritage. The only instruments they brought with them from Africa were rhythmic or rhythmic-melodic ones, and voices; but the characteristic timbres and inflexions of the African voice have coloured every jazz instrument since.

It may be well to point out, as clearly as possible, that none of these musical elements need be connected with race, in the biological sense of the word. There is no proof that the black sense of rhythm is 'inborn': it is learned like anything else. The herding together of blacks as slaves and their subsequent social segregation are quite enough to account for the great and persistent strength of the original Africanisms. Nor do these make jazz into an 'African music'. One has only to listen to West African music of any sort to see the difference, and as a matter of fact, modern West Africans have been rather slower to take to jazz than South Africans or young Englishmen who have no traditional link with it. They prefer, if anything, the Caribbean forms of Afro-American music.

Reasonably pure African music survived in America, partly in ritual music, pagan and more or less christianized, and in such things as work-songs and hollers. In Louisiana it was to some extent officially encouraged as a safety-valve for the slaves, perhaps much as tribal dancing is encouraged by the South African authorities among their serfs. The officially sponsored voodoo drum-dances on Congo Square in New Orleans did not die out until the middle 1880s. (They seem to have been started after the Napoleonic Wars.) However, black music rapidly began to fuse with white components, and the evolution of jazz is the result of the fusion.

Jazz arose at the point where three different European cultural traditions intersected: the Spanish, the French, and the Anglo-Saxon. Each on its own had produced a characteristic Afro-European musical fusion: Latin-American and Caribbean music, Caribbean-French music (as in Martinique), and various forms of Afro-Anglo-Saxon music, of

which the spiritual gospel song, and country blues are, for our purposes, the most important. (On the North American continent we can probably neglect the Indian component.) The Mississippi Delta, with its Protestant Anglo-Saxon hinterland, its arms opening on the Spanish-Caribbean, and its native French culture, combined all these as no other region did.

Afro-Spanish influence affected jazz only as a 'Spanish tinge', to quote the pioneer New Orleans musician Ferdinand 'Jelly-Roll' Morton: an admixture of certain rhythms such as the tangana, or the habañera which, as W. C. Handy already noted, roused a particularly vivid response among continental blacks.[‡] The deliberate adoption of Afro-Cuban rhythms in modern jazz, which included the importation of Afro-Cuban ritual drummers such as Chano Pozo, does not belong to the prehistory of jazz. It is fair to say that Afro-Latin-American music, which is probably the only modern musical idiom which can rival jazz in its capacity to conquer other cultures, went its own way, and only overlapped at the edges with jazz.

The French musical tradition is far more important, particularly as it was fully assimilated by the peculiar class of freed slaves which grew up in New Orleans: the *gens de couleur* or Creoles. They were normally former black mistresses of French settlers and their descendants. The Creoles in turn brought it among the lower-caste blacks in the 1880s, when the progress of segregation deprived them of their privileged position. The instrumentation of early New Orleans jazz, which is essentially that of the military band, the instrumental technique, particularly obvious in that French speciality, the woodwind, the repertoire of marches, quadrilles, waltzes, and the like—all are unmistakably French, as indeed are the dialect and the names of many of the early (Creole) New Orleans musicians: Bechet, Dominique, St Cyr, Bigard, Picou, Piron, and the rest. It has been pointed out, incidentally,¹ that Martinique, where similar conditions obtained, has developed a musical blending which is remarkably similar to that of New Orleans Creole music.[‡]

Equally important, probably, is the French—or perhaps more exactly the Mediterranean or Catholic—social tradition of New Orleans: the profusion of public festivals, carnivals, fraternities (which merged easily

with the strong African *penchant* for secret societies), and parades, in which New Orleans jazz grew up. The jazz band, after all, is the most characteristic product of jazz, and only an area with a very large and constant demand for bands was likely to produce it.

The Anglo-Saxon components are in many respects the most fundamental. They consist of the English language, the religion and religious music of the colonists and, in a smaller way, their secular folk-songs and folk-music. After the emergence of jazz a fourth component became, alas, of growing importance: commercial popular music, which is itself a mixture of all sorts of elements, including, even before the triumph of the diluted jazz idiom, some coloured ones.

The English language provided the words of black speech and song, and in it black Americans have created, with the jazz idiom, the finest body of English folk-poetry since the Scots ballads: the work-song, gospel song, and secular blues. The secular music of the colonists—perhaps mostly the Scots-Irish poor whites of the South—provided a mass of songs many of which, taken up and modified by the black travelling minstrels, entered the jazz repertoire. *Careless Love*, the Kentucky mountain ballad, or *St James' Infirmary*, whose derivation from an early English original A. L. Lloyd has traced, are examples. After 1800 religion—more especially the 'great awakening' which swept the Southern and frontier poor, black and white, into a frenzied, egalitarian, democratic Protestant sectarianism—provided the musical framework. The harmonies of the blues, as distinct from semi-African melodies and rhythms, are those of Moody and Sankey's type of hymn. But perhaps more important than the juicy harmonium chords, which were thus later to be strangely adapted to jazz, was the fact that the 'great awakening' achieved the first systematic blending of European and African music in the U.S.A. outside New Orleans. Moreover, since this was not the imposition of organization and orthodoxy from above, but a largely spontaneous mass conversion from below, the two were equally blended, the African component not being subordinated to the European. More: it did not even subordinate European folk-music to European art-music. Culturally the 'great awakening' was the counterpart to the American War of Independence; or perhaps more precisely, to the rise of Jacksonian frontier democracy. It ensured that religious music, white and black,

should remain a people's music, just as the defeat of Hamilton's by Jefferson's ideals ensured that American secular music should remain a people's music. From our point of view the important thing about this was that even black music thus won its right to independent development.

For the crucial factor in the development of jazz, as of all American popular music, the factor which more than any other accounts for the unique American phenomenon of a vigorous and resistant folk-music in a rapidly expanding capitalist society, is that it was never swamped by the cultural standards of the upper classes. English musical working-class culture in the nineteenth century consisted of a patently dying rural and pre-industrial folk-music,⁸ a musically extremely shoddy music-hall song, and the twin pillars of organized working-class music, the classic oratorio and the brass band. But however admirable the *Messiah* or the test pieces at the brass-band festivals, they are working-class conquests of orthodox culture, not independent folk-music. American popular and folk-music in the nineteenth century retained the initiative, and its persistent supremacy over Britain, even in the field of commercial pop music, derives largely from this.⁹

THE EVOLUTION OF BLACK FOLK MUSIC

Once the initial blending of the components had taken place, black folk-music began to evolve fairly rapidly. The details of this evolution before the 1890s are largely obscure, since it was not systematically observed.

The sung blues, the heart of jazz, may have emerged in its most primitive forms even before the Civil War, though almost certainly not yet in the standard twelve-bar form, and quite certainly as yet without using European or any other harmony. Possibly, as Wilder Hobson suggests, it—

may originally have consisted merely in the singing, over a steady, percussive rhythm, of lines of variable length, the length being

determined by what phrase the singer had in mind, with equally variable pauses (the accompanying rhythm continuing) determined by how long it took the singer to think up another phrase.

Possibly it emerged out of field-hollers or work-songs, or secularized pieces of gospel music. After black emancipation its evolution was greatly speeded up, if only because of the emergence of professional black beggar-minstrels, often blind, who roamed the road, some of whom have fortunately been recorded in our century. However it appears not to have acquired its name before the early twentieth century.² The important point about the blues is that it marks not merely a musical, but a social evolution: the emergence of a particular form of *individual* song commenting on everyday life. No doubt the banjo, an African instrument which could be adapted for melody, was used to accompany it. The blues turned into an instrumental form on the pianos of barrooms, barrel-houses, honky-tonks, and brothels of the South, most probably in those of navvies' and other labourers' camps, perhaps in the South-West. It has been traced back to the 1880s.

The first women who sang it publicly were almost certainly prostitutes like Mamie Desdoumes of New Orleans—'a hustlin' woman. A blues-singing poor gal. Used to play pretty passable piano around them dance-halls on Perdido Street', as Bunk Johnson recalls.³ But that was probably not before 1900 or so.

The first *spirituals* go back much earlier—before 1800 certainly. The various stages of their evolution from the primitive ring-shout to modern forms need not detain us, and the evolution of the special branch of the concert spiritual need not concern us, for this most Europeanized form of American black music has evolved far away from jazz. Spirituals and gospel songs at all stages of evolution continue to be sung or chanted, and all of them have continued to provide an inexhaustible reservoir for jazz in general and for particular jazz pieces. Thus the blues *How Long, How Long* is said to derive from a spiritual, *St James' Infirmary* echoes *Keep Your Hand on the Plough, Hold On*, and the last chorus of the *St Louis Blues*, according to its composer, owes much to the eloquence of Brother Lazarus Gardner, presiding Elder of the African Methodist

Episcopal Church of Florence, Ala. We need merely note that the separation of blacks into wholly black churches—mostly by secession from mixed churches in which they occupied a lower rank—began on a significant scale in 1816, when the African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church became an independent sect, but became a mass movement in the Civil War period. Perhaps from our point of view the crucial decade in this development, which naturally intensified the black character of spiritual music, was the segregation of the black Baptists, between 1865 and the 1880s, for this denomination and the twentieth-century (and therefore segregated) ‘shouting’ sects like the Pentecostal Holiness Churches, Churches of God in Christ, and the like, have made the most powerful single religio-musical contribution to jazz.

Meanwhile a second phase of the blending of African and European music took place. This time—and forever after—it was not religious song, but commercial popular entertainment, which stirred the mixture. Blacks naturally entered the profession of entertaining whites early, partly because they were good at it, partly because it was their best chance of leaving the worst forms of slavery or labouring, partly because slave-owners would naturally recruit their musicians, like their house servants, from among the slaves. A good many blacks thus learned white music, and no doubt in performing it imbued it with some of their traditions. In turn, white composers like Stephen Foster introduced some characteristic Southern black touches into white song, and in the North a flourishing industry of imitation black entertainers developed, black-faced and banjo-strumming. One may hope that Hitler is kept restless in his grave by the thought that it was pioneered by a German, Gottlieb Graupner who sang *The Gay Negro Boy* to banjo accompaniment in the opera *Oronooko* at the Federal Theatre, Boston, in 1799. Most of the minstrels, who became the rage from 1830 to the beginning of our century—they still live a shadowy existence on remote British seaside piers—were whites, but elements of black music penetrated through them into American popular music. In fact it was the most important channel through which black influences first passed into pop music. But it also served as a training ground for black musicians in European-style popular music, and later as an employer of early jazz and ragtime players. Minstrelsy was a channel which could be navigated both ways.

By the 1890s this mixture was about to reach boiling-point. In and around St Louis, where West-Midwest and South meet, the first identifiable style of jazz emerged: *ragtime*. This was almost exclusively a style of solo pianists, trained in European music and often with high musical ambitions: Scott Joplin, its most noted composer-player, composed a still-born ragtime opera in 1915, and James P. Johnson, the glory of Harlem's ragtime pianists, created equally unsuccessful symphonies, choral works, and concertos. The black tradition was dominant, because ragtime was syncopated rhythm; limited, because it was nothing else. By 1900 Tin Pan Alley had taken it over. Thus the perennial pattern of an original jazz style, almost immediately absorbed and vulgarized by pop music, was established from the start. Perhaps a little later the second independent jazz style appears: the *classical blues*, sung by professional women entertainers on the music-hall stage. The 'mother of the blues', 'Ma Rainey' (Gertrude Pridgett), a trouper's daughter, soon to be married to William Rainey of the 'Rabbit Foot Minstrels', seems to have begun singing the stage blues around 1902. The last decades of the century were also, as we have seen, the formative period in the development of the blues piano. Meanwhile there is a little evidence that in Southern cities like Atlanta, Mobile, and Charleston, the elements of an Afro-American band music were also emerging.⁴ None of these were yet within range of Tin Pan Alley.

It is therefore obvious that jazz was not simply 'born in New Orleans'. In one way or another the mixture between European and African elements was crystallizing into musical shape in many parts of America. Nevertheless, New Orleans can defend its title as the cradle of jazz against all comers, for there, and there alone, did the jazz band emerge as a mass phenomenon. How massive is indicated by the startling fact that this city of, say, 89,000 black inhabitants—the size of Cambridge—in 1910 contained at least *thirty* bands whose reputation has survived. The priority of New Orleans cannot be disputed. No other jazz players who have since become more widely known were born as early as the 1870s, like Bunk Johnson (tpt), Alphonse Picou (clt), or Manuel Perez (tpt), not to mention the legendary Buddy Bolden, who led the first historically attested jazz band around 1900.

Why did jazz emerge at the end of the nineteenth century? Why did it emerge above all in New Orleans?

The second half of the nineteenth century was a revolutionary period in the popular arts everywhere, though this has been overlooked by those orthodox observers of the arts who are snobs. Thus in Britain the music hall separated from its parent, the pub, in the 1840s and 50s.⁵ By general agreement it reached its peak in the 1880s and 90s, which also saw the startlingly rapid rise of the other phenomenon of working-class culture, professional football. In France the period after the Commune produced the working-class *chansonnier*, and after 1884 his culturally more ambitious bohemian derivation, the Montmartre cabaret: the great Aristide Bruant produced his famous collection of lumpen-proletarian art 'Dans La Rue' in 1889.⁶ In Spain an evolution strikingly similar to that in America produced the *cante hondo*, the Andalusian *flamenco*, which, like the blues it so much resembles, appeared as a professionally transformed folk-song in the 'musical cafés' of Cadiz and Seville, Málaga and Cartagena, from the 1860s to 1900s.^{||}

All these phenomena have two things in common: they arose out of the professional entertainment of the 'labouring poor', and they arose in big cities. They are, in fact, the product of urbanization; commercially, because it became worthwhile at a certain point to invest a fair amount of money in such entertainment, culturally, because the town poor (including the recently settled immigrants from the country or abroad) needed a special kind of entertainment. An analogous development for the middle classes occurred at the same period: the rise of musical comedy or operetta, but this had very little bearing on the evolution of the working-class arts. Now such working-class entertainment was of two types: either it might grow out of the professional entertainments which had always been provided in pre-industrial times, especially in permanent great metropolitan towns, as in the variety theatre, which combined, and still combines, aspects of the circus, the freak show, the sporting event, song-and-dance, and the rest. The New Orleans jazz band was clearly a development of such a metropolitan tradition of entertainment, in this case the public musical parade. (It is significant that it owes little to official dance music, as witness the virtual absence of

stringed instruments.) Or else such entertainment might be a straight development of rural or urban amateur folk-song, as in the case of the flamenco and the blues. It is obvious that all country blacks knew the blues; equally so that a commercial demand for public performance of it could only arise when 'those blues, cotton-picking Negroes, what they called in the old days yard and field Negroes' became a box office force. This process is not recorded for the blues, but for the flamenco it is remembered by the old minstrel Fernando el de Triana, who claims to have been the first to carry the original miners' fandangos of Alosno into the wider world:

All the world knows that for the past forty years pretty nearly all retail shops in Spain were run by sons of this famous mountain pueblo ... There was no capital city in Spain without its group of Alosneros, who, in their leisure hours, kept only their own company. As they were always great lovers of song, they frequented the singing cafés, and since I was in those days the idol of the Alosneros, and travelled all over the place, singing professionally in the cafés, I always came across them in all parts of Spain.⁷

The emancipation of the slaves and the northern migration produced a black proletariat technically free to choose its own entertainment. A glance at the figures of black urban population in 1900—87,000 in Washington, D.C., 78,000 in New Orleans, 61,000 in New York and Philadelphia, 79,000 in Baltimore, 30–50,000 in several other cities^{**}—shows that they already provided a modest public. But then, the entrepreneurs who catered for them were also modest like those who ran the tent shows and the Savannah joints in which, by 1903, 'a low form of vaudeville is carried on'.⁸ However, by 1910–14 the first ambitious theatres for an exclusively black audience were being built —e.g. the New Palace in New York, the Booker T. Washington in St Louis, the Pekin and the State in Chicago.⁹ What is equally to the point, the striking increase in the demand for entertainment among the white poor in the rapidly growing cities accelerated the development of music among black

entertainers. But among these cities New Orleans occupied a special position as the unique metropolis of the South. With 216,000 inhabitants in 1880—a population almost doubled since 1850—it is very much larger than its rivals in the Deep South.

This rapidly swelling metropolis, export port, and capital of the plantation country of the Mississippi Delta has odd parallels with the very similarly placed port cities in which the Andalusian flamenco began its career: Seville and Cadiz. Two things helped to precipitate jazz as we know it there: the breakdown of the old traditional slave culture and the fall of the free ‘creoles of colour’. The 1880s are the crucial period for both: the Congo Square dances were abandoned and systematic racial discrimination came. The end of formalized African entertainment left the way free for a much less inhibited mixture of European and African idioms in the street parades and other brass band music which flourished like poppies in a cornfield after the Civil War.

The fall of the Creoles brought European musical know-how into the new popular idiom, but above all, it secured the musical supremacy of the low-caste, black, ‘uptown’, blues blacks. There are plenty of Creoles in New Orleans jazz, but (except perhaps for the clarinets) they had to learn to play dirty and improvise like the uptown boys. As the disgusted old Creole Paul Dominguez told Alan Lomax, ‘A fiddler is *not* a violinist, but a violinist can be a fiddler. If I wanted to make a living I had to be rowdy like the other group. I had to jazz it or rag it or any other damn thing.... Bolden did that.’¹⁰ Bolden and Bunk Johnson and Johnny Dodds and Louis Armstrong and Mutt Carey and Jim Robinson and other descendants of slaves from the Anglo-Saxon hot-gospelling Protestant upcountry.

Out of this mixture New Orleans jazz—perhaps still much like ragtime European marches—appeared, like a black Venus out of the foam. And we may still hear it, in its primitive form, in the famous funeral marches reconstructed by Jelly-Roll Morton and Louis Armstrong for the gramophone, and in the classic description of old Bunk Johnson:

On the way to the cemetery with an Odd Fellow or a Mason — they always buried with music, you see—we would always use slow, slow numbers, such as *Nearer My God to Thee*, *Flee as a*

Bird to the Mountains, Come Thee Disconsolate. We would use most any 4/4, played very slow. They walked very slow behind the body.

After we would get to the cemetery, and after the particular person were put away, the band would come on to the front, out of the graveyard. Then the lodge would come out ... and they called roll, fall in line, and then we'd march away from the cemetery by the snare-drum only, until we got about a block or two blocks away from the cemetery. Then we'd go right on into ragtime—what people call today swing—ragtime. We would play *Didn't He Ramble*, *When the Saints Go Marching In*, that good old piece *Ain't Gonna Study War No More*, and several others we would have, and we'd play them just for that effect.¹¹

And meanwhile, in the honky-tonks, there were the hustlin' girls and 'those blues players that didn't know nothing but the blues', like the *Game Kid*, who played them all night long in the good-time houses, for a couple of dollars' worth of drinks:

*I could sit right here and think a thousand miles away
Yes, I could sit right here and think a thousand miles away.
Got the blues so bad, I cannot remember the day.*

Notes

- ¹. Marshall Stearns, *The Story of Jazz* (London 1957), 32.
- ². Samuel B. Charters, *The Country Blues* (1960), 23–5.
- ³. Alan Lomax, *Mr Jelly-Roll* (New York 1950), 21n.
- ⁴. Stearns, 32.
- ⁵. C. D. Stuart and A. D. Park, *The Variety Stage* (London 1895).
- ⁶. A. Zevaes, *Aristide Bruant* (Paris 1943).
- ⁷. Fernando el de Triana, *Arte y artistas flamencos* (Madrid 1952), 140–1.
- ⁸. *Some Notes on Negro Crime* (ed. W. E. B. du Bois, Atlanta 1904), 51.
- ⁹. A. Green and J. Laurie, *Show Biz from Vaude to Video* (New York 1951), 39; R. Blesh and H. Janis, *They All Played Ragtime* (London 1958), 261–2.
- ¹⁰. Alan Lomax, *Mr Jelly-Roll*, 86.
- ¹¹. Stearns, 61.

* There is some argument about the characteristic 'blue' tonality of American black music, which does not seem at all general in pure West African music. It has been explained as an 'Africanization' of European scales.

† Handy wrote a 'tangana' passage into his famous *St Louis Blues*, where it may still be heard.

‡ But Mobile, Ala., though virtually a twin to New Orleans, did not develop such a blending. Why it did not is one of the many problems of jazz history which await solution.

§ The efforts of devoted folk-music lovers like A. L. Lloyd, Ewan McColl, and Alan Lomax have not succeeded in seriously shaking the traditional view that English folk-song went into a permanent decline from the 1840s on.

¶ After all, even in the period when American political and economic power was not yet as great as ours, the traffic in song hits was mostly one way, as witness Stephen Foster's songs, *Nellie Dean*, *Tararaboomdeay*, *Waiting for the Robert E. Lee*, and the rest.

|| Thanks to the respect of progressive Spanish poets and folklorists for their common people, its early history is much better known than that of the blues. 'Demofilo'—the great folklorist and father of poets, Antonio Machado Alvarez—published the first sketch of its evolution and collection of its verses in the 1880s. His pseudonym 'friend of the people' indicates the spirit in which Spanish intellectuals approach their subject.

** Chicago, St Louis, Memphis, Atlanta.